

MODAL JAZZ 101

FROM DIGGING DEEPER VIDEO #136

Modal Jazz can be a scary sounding term, but it's quite easy to understand. In short, a Modal Jazz song uses long expanses of one chord (one mode, one scale) as the harmonic under-pinning of the song, as opposed to the more dense chord progressions of a typical song. A Modal Jazz song has it's harmony "thinned out," historically a reaction against the "thick" chords and harmonic rhythm of the bebop era.

"Less chords" sounds easier, right? Well, Modal Jazz has many complexities and issues of it's own for us to solve. Let's dig into some of the most common questions and stumbling blocks here.

- 1) What is the mode we are supposed to use?
- 2) I get lost when I'm playing modal jazz.
- 3) I don't know what to do, what to play.

#1 - "So What" by Miles Davis



#2 - Four Measure Phrases



#3 - Simple Structures (scale in 3rds)

